UNIT IV · CONTEMPORARY DEBATES

Diversity

Understanding India's Social and Cultural Plurality

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BA Programme — Economics and Political Science

Presentation topic: Diversity







Photos (Wikimedia Commons): Hornbill Festival, Nagaland — Vikramjit Kakati, CC BY-SA 4.0; Pongal kolam — Priyadharshini Mohanraj, CC BY-SA 4.0; Eid prayers, Fatehpuri Masjid, Delhi — Ministry of Culture, GODL-India

What is diversity?

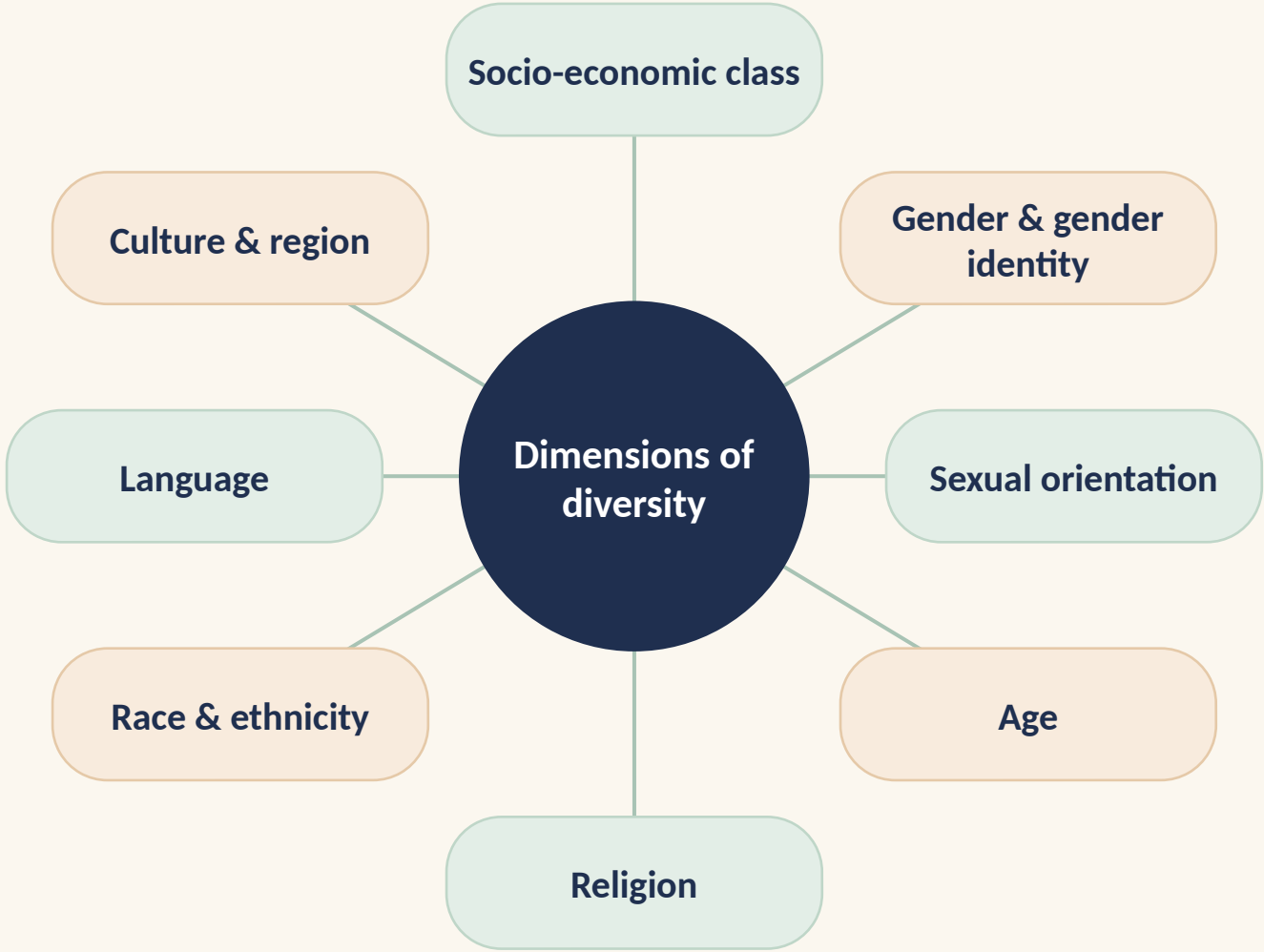
> *"The existence of a broad variety of unique individuals, objects, or social constructs within a given group or civilisation."*
>
> — Textbook definition, p. 72

Recognising diversity

Noticing that people differ.

Including diversity

Making sure people from every background can take part, be heard and reach opportunities.



Source: Textbook (Batham, 2023), pp. 72–74. The dimensions shown are those the textbook names.

Why diversity matters in a democracy



Representation

A diverse society can reflect the views and interests of all its people, not just a small segment.



Equity

People of every background are more likely to get equal access to resources and opportunities.



Dialogue and understanding

Contact across differences can build tolerance and reduce discrimination.



Innovation and progress

Different experiences bring original ideas for solving complex problems.

Key point: the textbook says diverse societies are “more likely” to gain these benefits. They follow only when institutions make room for everyone — being present is not the same as being heard.

Source: Textbook (Batham, 2023), p. 73 — the four reasons are the textbook's own.

India: a land of diversity

कोस-कोस पर बदले पानी, चार कोस पर वाणी

Kos-kos par badle paani, chaar kos par vaani

“The water changes every kos; the way people speak changes every four kos.”

A kos is an old unit of distance (about 2–4 km; it varied by region). The textbook calls it a unit of area.

28 + 8

States and Union Territories (since 2020)

22

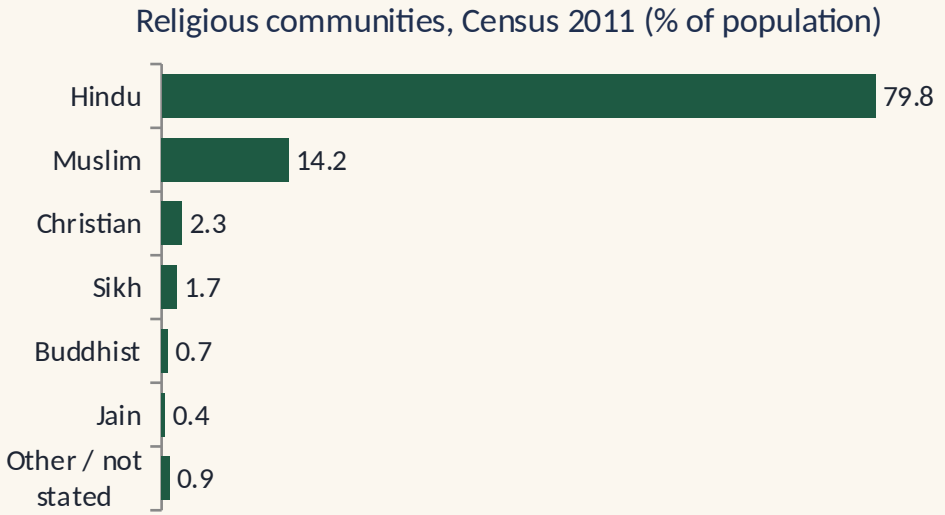
languages in the Eighth Schedule of the Constitution

121

languages, grouped from 19,569 mother-tongue names (Census 2011)



Hornbill Festival, Nagaland. Photo: Vikramjit Kakati, CC BY-SA 4.0



Sources: Textbook, p. 73 (saying; 28 states, 8 UTs; 22 languages; “19,500 dialects”); Census of India 2011, Language Paper 1 of 2018 and religion data (C-1). Census 2027 figures are not yet published.

Six reasons for India's diversity

1. Ancestry and migration

Many waves of settlement over thousands of years. The textbook's ‘racial groups’ come from the 1931 Census, a colonial typology; genetics shows mixed ancestry, not separate races.

2. Religion

Birthplace of Hinduism, Buddhism, Jainism and Sikhism; home to Islam, Christianity and other faiths, each with many sects.

3. Language

Indo-Aryan (about 78%) and Dravidian (about 19.6%) families, plus Austroasiatic, Tibeto-Burman and others (Census 2011).

4. Caste and jati

Four varnas but thousands of jatis, traditionally tied to occupation. Education and inter-caste marriage are making jati more flexible.

5. Geography

Seventh-largest country: young Himalayas, old Aravallis, cold desert (Ladakh), hot desert (Thar), long coasts and fertile plains.

6. Culture

Hills, plains, coasts and deserts shape different ways of life, architecture, dance forms and folk songs.

Sources: Textbook, pp. 74–75; Guha (1935), Census of India 1931; Reich et al. (2009); Narasimhan et al. (2019); AAPA (2019); Census 2011 language data; Dirks (2001).

Unity in diversity: the constitutional foundations

The Constitution of India — one framework for a diverse nation

Fundamental rights

Arts. 14–15

Equality before law; no discrimination on grounds of religion, race, caste, sex or place of birth.

Freedom of movement

Art. 19(1)(d)

Every citizen may move freely throughout India — and settle anywhere (Art. 19(1)(e)).

Secularism

Arts. 25–28

No state religion; freedom of conscience and worship for all. ‘Secular’ added to the Preamble in 1976.

Economic integration

GST, 1 July 2017

The same trade rules across states; GST created one national tax on goods and services.

Base: one government framework in three tiers — Union, States and local bodies. Common rules create shared ground; they do not erase regional or social inequality.

Sources: Textbook, p. 75–76 (factors 1–4); Constitution of India, Arts. 14–15, 19, 25–28; 42nd Amendment (1976); 101st Amendment (2016) and GST rollout (2017).

Shared experiences across a diverse country



Festivals

Diwali, Eid, Christmas, Gurpurab and more are celebrated widely, often across communities. Makar Sankranti is solar, not lunar as the textbook says, so its date is fixed.



The monsoon

June–September rains bring about three-quarters of India's yearly rainfall (IMD), shaping farming, food, festivals and daily life.



Language, cinema and cricket

Hindi and English are the Union's official languages; Bollywood spreads Hindi and cricket draws fans nationwide. Yet Hindi is the mother tongue of 43.6% (Census 2011).

Around 14 January — one harvest festival, many names (textbook, p. 76):

- Makar Sankranti · UP, Bihar, MP, Delhi
- Uttarayan · Gujarat
- Magh Bihu · Assam
- Lohri · Punjab
- Thai Pongal · Tamil Nadu
- Suggi Habba · Karnataka
- Shishur Saenkrant · Kashmir
- Poush Sankranti · West Bengal

Sources: Textbook, p. 76; India Meteorological Department (2022); Census 2011 language tables (C-16, C-17); Constitution of India, Art. 343.

Debates: representation and affirmative action

	One view	Another view	Indian context
Political representation	Parties and institutions should mirror the diverse people they serve.	Representatives should be chosen for ability, not identity.	Lok Sabha reserves 84 seats for SCs and 47 for STs (Arts. 330, 332). One-third of seats for women (106th Amendment, 2023) begins only after the next census and delimitation.
Affirmative action	Reservation corrects historical prejudice against groups such as Dalits and Adivasis and secures real equality.	Critics, mostly from dominant groups, call it discriminatory and say it replaces individual merit.	Arts. 15(4), 16(4) allow quotas; Indra Sawhney (1992) set a 50% ceiling; the 10% EWS quota (2019) was upheld in 2022. Census 2027 will record caste.

Sources: Textbook, pp. 76–77 (both views); Constitution of India; Indra Sawhney v. Union of India (1992); Janhit Abhiyan v. Union of India (2022); 106th Amendment Act, 2023.

Debates: culture, work and migration

Cultural appropriation

Exchange: food, dress and ideas have always travelled; sharing connects people.

Appropriation: taking a marginalised culture's traditions without credit can exploit or erase it.

Example: Prada's 2025 sandals resembled GI-tagged Kolhapuri chappals; after protests it acknowledged the Indian inspiration.

Diversity at work

For: diverse teams aid creativity; firms should promote diversity in hiring and promotion.

Against: the most qualified applicant should come first.

Example: large and listed companies must have a woman director (Companies Act, 2013). Haryana's 75% local-jobs quota was struck down by the High Court (2023).

Immigration and nationalism

For: migration drives economic development.

Concern: some fear it weakens national identity and security — a contested view.

Example: 45.6 crore internal migrants (Census 2011); debates over the CAA (2019) and Assam's NRC (2019); immigration debates in the USA.

Common thread: each debate asks how to combine equal rights and openness with respect for difference. The answers depend on fair rules and institutions.

Sources: Textbook, p. 77; Companies Act 2013, s. 149(1); P&H High Court, Nov 2023; Census 2011 migration tables (D-series); news reports on Prada (June–July 2025).

Conclusion and references

“The problem does not lie in diversity but in the handling of diversity in any society.”

— Textbook, p. 77

1. Diversity is multidimensional: religion, language, caste, region, class, gender and more.

2. Unity rests on constitutional values (equality, rights, secularism) and shared everyday life, not on sameness.

3. Debates on quotas, culture, work and migration are about including everyone fairly. Diversity is neither automatic harmony nor the problem itself.

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